discovered Humayun's weakness—a certain predictable tendency to leave a campaign half-finished—he resolved to use all means possible to hustle his elder brother out of his birthright in Hindustan. One of these means was the kidnapping of Humayun's only son, Akbar, and his sister. The taking of royal hostages was an accepted strategy in these wars of succession, a way of exerting very effective pressure on rivals to the throne and containing their ambitions. The unfortunate children of unsuccessful claimants were often imprisoned for life, miserable shadows of their fathers' lost ambitions.

In 1544, when Humayun rode back into Hindustan after exile in Persia, his two young children were summoned by Kamran to his court in Kabul where it was hoped their presence would deter an attack by their father. This terrifying, headlong rush in the swirling snow, his fate uncertain, was very likely one of the first memories Akbar would have.

The historical record does not tell us whether the terrified toddler in the snowy wastes of Afghanistan would have any inkling that, in a little over ten years, he would be emperor of Hindustan and that, in the course of a nearly fifty-year reign, he would create one of the most magnificent empires in history. What is known is that when Akbar—whose name itself means 'Great'* and is therefore in no further need of the descriptor—became emperor at the age of only thirteen upon the unexpected death of his father, Humayun, there were very few signs of the remarkable legacy he would ultimately bequeath to the land that would come to be known as India.

In fact, Akbar was a distracted, undisciplined, and rambunctious child and youth who, in the parlance of the twenty-first century, may have suffered from attention-deficit disorder. So unruly and self-willed was Akbar that no tutor was able to hold his attention and he grew up effectively unschooled and practically illiterate. This would remain one of the great mysteries of Akbar's life, for he would eventually be known for his reverence for learning, penmanship, books, and scholarship, and would patronize some of the most extraordinary works of writing, translation, and illustration ever undertaken in the country. Scholars have theorized that Akbar's illiteracy may have stemmed from dyslexia but, whatever the cause, Akbar's unconventional childhood, especially for a prince, meant that he developed a certain way of relating to the world around him, a tendency to experience reality in a visceral, malleable manner which he would later rely on to judge ideas and men. No new thought, or new